more of their land. In their frustration and anger, many Palestinians switched their support from the PLO to more **militant** Palestinian groups. Among these groups was **Hamas**, whose initials in Arabic stood for the Islamic Resistance Movement.

Suicide bombings and assassination 1995–7

Key question
What effects did suicide bombings have?

Hamas had opposed the 'peace process' because they believed that the Palestinians gained little. For a start, there was no Israeli recognition of Palestine's right to an independent Palestinian state, let alone the promise of such a state. Besides which, it was the declared aim of Hamas to destroy the state of Israel. Support for Hamas increased dramatically after a Jewish settler, Baruch Goldstein, went on the rampage and killed 29 Palestinians at a mosque in Hebron, on the West Bank, in 1994. Organisations like Hamas blamed the Israeli government for not disarming the settlers and for allowing this to happen. Israeli settlers had the army and police to protect them as well as being heavily armed themselves. Most Palestinians felt very vulnerable. Over the next few years, Hamas embarked on a campaign of suicide bombings, both in Israel itself and in the occupied territories. In July 1997, the *Guardian* newspaper carried a report of one such suicide bombing in Jerusalem:

Horror in the Market Place
Israel Stunned as 15 Die in Suicide Bombing, Shattering Peace Hopes

The bombers dressed in black. They wore suits and ties and carried briefcases. They parked their car a few hundred yards from Jerusalem's market and walked into the dense mix of fruit, vegetables and heaving crowds. The two men were almost certainly in sight of one another when they pulled the cords on their twin bombs.

By late last night, the toll was 15 dead and more than 150 wounded. All Palestinians working in Israel were ordered back to the West Bank and Gaza, which have been sealed off.

Yasser Arafat, the Palestinian leader, declared a state of emergency yesterday in the territories controlled by his Palestinian Authority and began arresting Islamic militants. Leaflets circulating in Palestinian areas claimed the attack had been carried out by the main Palestinian extremist group, Hamas.

'I condemn completely this terrorist act because it is against the peace process, against the Palestinians and against the Israelis', said Arafat.

Bombings like this made the Israeli government take a harder line. They blamed Arafat and the PA for not controlling the militants; Israeli troops moved back into areas in Gaza and the West Bank which they had recently left. **Curfews** were imposed in

Key terms

Militant
A person who supports the use of force.

Hamas
Founded in Gaza in 1988 by Sheikh Ahmed Yassin, a religious teacher. The movement opposed the Oslo Accords and refused to recognise the state of Israel.

Curfew
A time or signal after which it was compulsory for people to remain indoors.